



Security Watch

Firefox IDN URL Domain Name Buffer Overflow

The Problem

On September 9, a vulnerability was discovered in Firefox, which could be exploited by malicious individuals to cause a DoS (Denial of Service) attack or to compromise a user's system. The vulnerability has been confirmed in the Firefox version 1.0.6, and is reported to affect versions prior to 1.0.6 as well as version 1.5 Beta 1.

The vulnerability is caused due to an error in the handling of IDN URLs containing the OxAD character in the domain name. This can be exploited to cause a buffer overflow. Security firm Secunia rates the vulnerability as "highly critical." (IDN stands for Internationalised Domain Name. IDN URLs can use more characters in domains names, besides letters and numbers, and specifically, characters in other (non-English) alphabets.)

Damages

Successful exploitation crashes Firefox, and may allow code execution on the user's computer. This, however, requires that the user is tricked into visiting a malicious Web site or opening a specially-crafted HTML file.

Precautions

Set the preference called 'network.enableIDN' to 'false'. This can be done in the 'prefs.js' file, or by typing "about:config" in the Firefox address bar and then editing the file that shows up.

unlock the account. He was also told that it generally took three to five business days to process the documents. But due to PayPal's previous arrangements with another NGO, the money could not be donated to Red Cross and eventually, all of it had to be refunded.

It's really sad when the facilitating medium itself acts up and proves to be the villain. Part of the 'ease of Web use' fame, PayPal perhaps chose the worst possible time to play truant. On the whole, though, the online community, especially bloggers, can pat themselves on the back, and perhaps this is one of the more reliable mediums we could turn to in the future.

FLICK OFF!

Flickr Users Don't Want Y! Accounts

Flickr, the photo-sharing portal, has had great success since its launch—and not without reason.

But the recent takeover of the portal by Yahoo! has irked a large number of members who have a rather subtle message for the Internet giant: Flick Off!

In response, a portion of the tight-knit photo community is protesting the forced move by threatening to abandon their accounts a day before the imposed deadline in 2006.

Under the group name 'Flick off,' more than 640 members are bemoaning the change and are discussing a migration of their own.

A faction of Flickr community is threatening a symbolic 'mass suicide' to protest closer integration with the Web site's new owner, Yahoo!.

What is being largely cited as pushy is that Yahoo! has asked all existing members to migrate their Flickr accounts and use only a Yahoo! login to sign-in.

In a clause in Flickr's FAQ, Yahoo! said it would migrate all independent account holders to its own network, requiring them to create a Yahoo! ID.

But it's not just the compulsory migration that has irked users. There are also doubts as to whether Yahoo! would start collecting user data.

"About the only worry I have that I have not yet seen an answer for is that I won't be able to remain logged in into Flickr without making it possible for Yahoo! to watch me use all their other services," posted a user in the Flick Off forum on the site.

In its notice, Yahoo! did not disclose the exact date when it will transition Flickr members to the Yahoo! network.

HOT

iPod Nano

Apple's latest offering is as thin as a pencil they say. With two variants—a 2 GB and 4 GB one, this flash memory based player is all set to capture the MP3 market with an affordable starting price of \$199 (approx Rs 8800).

NOT

iPod Mini

We all loved it and thought it was the coolest thing around when it was released. This was until the birth of the Nano. All our illusions disappeared and Apple decided that the Mini wasn't hot anymore. In the gadget world, smaller is hotter.

(Yahoo! bought Flickr shortly after it launched Yahoo! 360, a social network that combines a blogging tool, instant messaging, photo storage and sharing, and also Internet radio).



One Silly Question "Who Owns The Internet?"



"Reliance may own it in the future - they buy everything around them!!"
Mudasser Mulla, Mumbai



"I own the Internet... I can use it at will whenever I want to"
Janhvi Shah, Mumbai



"I think it is CERN, a group from Switzerland"
Ankit Shah, Gujarat



"Not me!!"
Aarti Subramaniam, Tamil Nadu



"It's the public who owns the Net!"
Karishma Kadam, Maharashtra